THE EASE OF LIVING

Launched in June 2010 by then external affairs minister S.M. Krishna, the Passport Seva Programme (PSP) has transformed the passport issuance process in India. It introduced a streamlined and digitised system for applications, with an initial plan to set up 77 Passport Seva Kendras (PSKs) in collaboration with Tata Consultancy Services. In 2017, the MEA joined hands with the Department of Posts to provide passport-related services at Head Post Offices (HPOs) in various states for ensuring a wider coverage. Today, the ministry's extensive infrastructure includes 535 passport application processing centres—93 PSKs and 442 Post Office PSKs—under the jurisdiction of 37 Regional Passport Offices (RPOs).

Online applications and real-time appointment scheduling through the 'mPassport Seva' mobile app has made the process user-friendly. Citizens now benefit from seamless services such as 24/7 support through a multilingual National Call Centre and Tatkaal facility for expedited processing in cases of emergency. Integration with police systems through the 'mPassport Police' app has accelerated background verification, while DigiLocker enables paperless documentation. PSKs deliver secure, end-to-end services while providing modern amenities to applicants. Their photographs and biometrics are captured on-site, with applications and documents digitised and securely stored for seamless processing. An Electronic Queue Management System ensures efficient, first-come-first-served application processing, while applicants wait in air-conditioned lounges. Special initiatives, such as increased appointment capacities and weekend drives, address the problem seasonal surges.

All these initiatives have helped reduce processing times significantly—7-10 days for 'normal' passports and 1–3 days for the ones issued under the Tatkaal scheme, according to information furnished by the MEA in the Lok Sabha in December 2023. This excludes the time taken for police verification. According to the ministry, wherever the 'mPassport Police' app is in use, the verification is completed within five days, though the all-India average is 14 days. In his message on Passport Seva Divas on June 24 last year, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar highlighted the remarkable progress made in delivering passport-related services in India—16.5 million such services delivered in 2023, an annual growth rate of 15 per cent.

With a budget of Rs 924.13 crore for 2024-25, the government continues to expand and enhance this system. Since its inception, over 100 million passports have been issued under the programme, which exemplifies the potential of e-governance to deliver citizen-centric services with efficiency and transparency. ■

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HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Renewing my passport was a breeze"

Working for a multinational IT firm, Pant recently had to get his passport renewed for an upcoming international travel. Remembering past hassles and his busy work schedule, he was anxious about delays but decided to try the Passport Seva portal. To his relief, the process was seamless—he completed the online application, uploaded documents, paid fees and scheduled an appointment effortlessly.

Although he got a date that was two weeks away, Pant was impressed when he finally reached the Passport Seva Kendra. "The staff was very polite and professional. The entire process took just 40 minutes," he recalls. The biggest surprise came when his renewed passport arrived within four working days. "It was a breeze," says Lalit. "I'm so glad I avoided the usual physical visits and paperwork." ■



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